political future. But once I'd entered the race, I wanted to see it through.

The North Carolina primary was coming up in late March and I had to pull off a victory there in order to remain a credible candidate. I stumped the state day and night and in a last-ditch effort gambled much of our remaining campaign funds to buy a half hour of airtime to present my case shortly before the election.

The gamble worked. The speech generated enough support for me to turn things around and we won North Carolina; this helped us raise the money needed to keep the campaign alive. After that, I won in Texas, Alabama, Georgia, California, and several other states, which set up a confrontation between Ford and me at the convention in Kansas City.

The votes of 1,140 delegates were needed to win the nomination. As the convention approached, the competition for delegates was nip and tuck and I came under pressure, especially from my more conservative supporters, to go on the attack against Ford.

Although I did make it clear I didn't like some things that had happened under his administration, such as the agreement giving away control of the Panama Canal, which Americans had bought and paid for, it wasn't in me to violate the Eleventh Commandment and I refused to attack Ford personally.

When the balloting was over, I had 1,070 votes—70 votes shy of victory—and Ford had 1,187. The nomination was his. I'd come close, but not close enough. It was a big disappointment because I hate to lose. But I'd always known that challenging an incumbent president was going to be difficult.

Ford's people sent signals to me that I could have the vice-presidential nomination if I wanted it, but for months I'd